Out There

By Jo Ann Beard

INTRODUCTION

Have you ever wanted to embark on a solo road trip as a woman, but talked yourself out of it for what seems like a million reasons? News reports of women violently attacked, carjacked, robbed, raped, or worse simply because they were driving alone. Decomposing bodies discovered by hikers and hunters, their bodies long abandoned. Images taped to tollbooth windows: Missing! Reward offered for her safe return. And yet despite the fear, many women still choose to travel alone, balancing their desire for independence with the need to stay safe . . .

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(Pg 144-151) It isn't even eight A.M. and I'm hot. I'm fifty miles from the motel and about a thousand and a half from home, in a little white Mazda with 140,000 miles on it. I'm all alone in Alabama, with only a cooler and a tape deck for company. It's already in the high 80s. Yesterday, coming up from the keys through Florida, I had a day-long anxiety attack. I kept thinking I saw alligators at the edge of the highway.

There were about four hundred exploded armadillos, too,

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but I got used to them. They were real, and real dead. I'm running away from running away from home. I bolted four weeks ago, leaving my husband to tend the dogs. He doesn't love me anymore, it's both trite and true. After thirteen years he came to realize that the more successful he got, the less he loved me. That's how he put it, late one night. He won that screaming match. He said, gently and sadly, "I feel sort of embarrassed of you." I said, "Of what? The way I look? The way I act?" And he said, softly, "Everything, sort of." And it was true.

Well, I decided to take a trip to Florida. Key West for four weeks, writing and seething and striking up conversations with strangers. I had my 35th birthday there, weeping into a basket of shrimp. Boy, do I need a cup of coffee.

At the end of this trip I will have driven 3,999 miles all alone, me and the windshield, me and the radio, me and the creepy alligators. Don't ask me why I didn't get that last mile in. I didn't though, and 4,000 sounds like a lot more than 3,999 does; I feel sort of embarrassed for myself.

My window is broken, the crank fell off in Tallahassee on the way down. In order to roll it up or down I have to put

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the crank back on and turn it slowly and carefully, using one hand to push up the glass. So, mostly I leave it down.

I'm on a little four-lane blacktop running through the Alabama countryside. It's pretty, too, better than Florida, which was billboards and condos built on old dump sites. This is like driving between rolling emerald carpets. You can't see the two lanes going in the opposite direction because there's a screen of trees. I'm starting to get in a good mood again.

Little convenience store, stuck out in the middle of nothing, a stain on the carpet. I'm gassing up, getting some coffee. My shirt is gaping open and I have nothing underneath it, but who cares, I'll never see these people again. What do I care what Alabama thinks about me. This is an unusual attitude for me. I'm practicing in anticipation of being dumped by my husband when I get back to Iowa.

I swagger from the gas pump to the store. I bring my coffee cup along and fill it at the counter. Various men, oldish and grungy, sit at tables eating eggs with wadded-up toast. They stare at me while they chew. I ignore them and pay the woman at the counter. She's smoking a cigarette so I envy her.

When I leave, the men are still staring in a sullen way. I rearrange all my junk so I have everything handy, choose a Neil Young tape, pop it in and then move back out on the highway. Back to the emerald carpet and the road home. Iowa is creeping toward me like a panther.

All I do is sing when I drive. Sing and think. On the way down I would weep uncontrollably, but I'm past that now. Now I suffer bouts of free-floating hostility, which is much better. I plan to use it when I get home.

A car swings up alongside me so I pause my singing until it goes past. People who sing in their cars cheer me up, but I'd rather not be caught doing it. On the road, we're all singing, picking our noses, embarrassing ourselves wildly; it gets tiresome. I pause and hum, but the car sticks alongside me so I glance over. It's a guy. He grins and makes a lewd gesture with his mouth. It's disgusting. *(demonstrates, tongue darting in and out, quickly)* A python testing its food.

Who do these men think they are? I've had my fill of it. He picked the wrong day to mess with me! I give him the

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finger, slowly and deliberately [then] take a sip of coffee.

He's still there. I can't believe this! He followed me from that convenience store. He has on a fishing hat with lures stuck in it. I saw him back there, but I can't remember if he was sitting with the other men or by himself. He's big, overweight, and dirty. His passenger-side window is down. He begins screaming at me.

The road is endless, there is nothing, no cars, no anything. The other two lanes still invisible behind their screen of trees. I'm all alone out here. With him -- screaming and screaming at me, reaching out his right arm like he's throttling me. I speed up. He speeds up, too, next to me. We're only a few feet apart, my window won't roll up. He's got slobber on his face. I slam on my brakes and for an instant he's ahead of me, I can breathe, then he slams on his brakes and we're next to each other again. [And] he's screaming he wants to kill me -- screaming and screaming. I stare straight ahead, hands at ten and two.

The front end of his car is moving into my lane. He's saying he'll cut me with a knife, how he'll do it -- I can't listen. The front end of his Impala is about four inches from my little white Mazda. I am absolutely terrified.

[But] I refuse to give him an inch. If I do, he'll have me off the road in an instant. I speed up, he speeds up, I slow down, he slows down. If I give him an inch, he'll shove me off the road get his hands on me, then the end will begin in some unimaginable, unspeakable style. There will be blood, he won't want me to die quickly.
I cannot let him push me over onto the gravel. His car noses less than two inches from mine; I'm getting rattled. My God, he can almost reach me through his window; he's moved over in his seat, driving just with the left hand. I move toward the center of the car, carefully, without swerving.

In the rearview mirror a speck appears. Don't look, watch your front end. I glance up again; it's a trucker. Suddenly a road appears on the right, a dirty and rutted thing leading off into the trees. He hits the brakes, drops behind, and takes it. In my rearview mirror I see that the license plate on the front of his car is buried in dried mud. That road is where he was hoping to push me. He wanted to push my car off the highway and get me on that road. He was hoping

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to do what maniacs, furious men do to women alongside roads, in woods.

By force of will, I slow down to 65, and wait for the truck to overtake me. As it moves in front of me I speed up enough to stay two car lengths behind it. It says ***England*** on the back, ornate red letters outlined in black. ***England***.

That guy chased me on purpose, he ***hated*** me, with more passion than anyone has ever felt for me. Ever.

Out there are all those decomposing bodies, all those disappeared daughters, discovered by joggers and hunters, their bodies long abandoned, the memory of final desperate moments lingering on the leaves, the trees, the mindless stumps and mushrooms. Images taped to tollbooth windows, faces pressed into the dirt alongside a path somewhere.

I want to roll my window up, but I'd have to stop and get the crank out and lift it by hand. I'm too scared. He's out there still, waiting behind the screen of trees. I have to follow ***England*** until I'm out of Alabama.

(thinking aloud) Green car, old Impala, unreadable license

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plate; lots of rust. Seat covers made out of that spongy stuff, something on the dashboard, a coffee cup or a sad Jesus. The fishing hat with a sweat ring around it right above the brim. Lures with feathers and barbs. I've never been so close to so much hatred in my whole life. ***He wanted to kill me.*** Me, of all people. Me.

I got onto the interstate, had the nerve to pee in a rest area, adrenaline running like an engine inside me, my keys threaded through my fingers in case anyone tried anything.

(beat)

(thinking aloud) I didn't do anything to earn it -- his anger. I didn't do anything.

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AWARD HISTORY

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